

Q What is your role in bringing out this version of AOO?

I have been an active developer with vast experience on the OpenOffice project. I have been working on this project since the beginning and have worked on the code even before it was open sourced. Since OpenOffice moved to Apache, I am acting as the release manager on behalf of our community to coordinate the relevant release items. But it is of course a huge community effort to bring new releases out. So many people are working behind the scenes to fix problems, implement new features, do the testing, write documentation, maintain the necessary infrastructure and keep it running.

Q Which one of the new features (added to the software) would you consider as your biggest achievement?

I worked mainly under the hood and did bug fixes and a major clean-up of the so called 3-layer structure. In the past, OpenOffice was organised in a 3-layer structure, theoretically to share some code between products that are based on the same code. But this introduced an unnecessary complexity, so I started to rework this structure and we will do further cleaning up or simplification to keep things more practical in the future.

Q Which office suite do you look up to? Can you share what you believe needs improvement in AOO?

I don't really look to other office suites but I am trying to understand what our users need and what we can do to make our office suite better to fulfil user requirements. Most of the existing office applications have so many features and many users don't even know about them. It's often a question of what you have to do with an office application. And that is the tricky part; different people use different features. But, in general, I would like to make the most often used features easier to use, and improve the work flow. I would want to make a useful feature like the style concept easier to use because I believe many users don't use it or even don't know it. Improved interoperability with Microsoft formats is always a big challenge and an ongoing task. But it seems that interoperability is important for document exchange, even though the Open Document Format (ODF) for me is the cleaner and better standard.

Q OpenOffice faces major competition from LibreOffice, which is growing at a much faster pace. What is AOO doing to retain its crown?

We are not competing against anyone. We're a non-profit organisation creating software for free distribution to the public. We believe we're offering a lot of benefits, including benefits to other products, like LibreOffice, that take our code and build upon it. Sixty million downloads in one year and currently about 1 million per week is not bad. It shows that the product brings some value to our users.

And is LibreOffice really growing faster? I don't know,

but I believe it is important to look a little bit closer at what's happening behind the scenes. Again, we don't want to compete with LibreOffice. Why should we? They are using our code and extend it with some features from external libraries that we can't use because of an incompatible licence. But in the end, it remains the OpenOffice code base, and they mirror our svn repository on a regular basis. They also merge fixes and new features like our sidebar in their code. That is, in principle, a good thing and the only concern I have is the way they do it. I believe it is counter-productive and doesn't help our users at all. Together we could achieve much more but that does not seem to be in the interests of some people who control LibreOffice. I can't change that and I can only say that we are open to collaborate with anybody who is using our code base and is interested to improve the code there where it originally comes from.

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Q LibreOffice makers claim that OpenOffice enjoys the advantage of 'brand value', which helps in the increased adoption of your software. What's your take on that?

Apache is a strong brand and Microsoft is an even stronger brand, but you don't see us complaining about Microsoft. Sure, the OpenOffice brand is well known and we continue the success story of OpenOffice. That is natural because we are OpenOffice, just to make it clear again—we are not a fork. The code base and everything else was granted and moved over to the Apache Software Foundation (ASF). We found a new home under the well known umbrella of the ASF, and OpenOffice is now controlled by the project and its members and not by a single company like it was before. It was a major task to migrate not only the source code but all the services that were running on Oracle servers before. We preserved everything to keep the history alive. And we did a major clean-up of the code and removed all dependencies to licence incompatible third party libraries. As one example of what we did for AOO 3.4, we removed six or seven external libs that were used for the svg import and Armin Le Grand, a core developer of AOO, reimplemented it from scratch. The new svg import is much better and will allow us future improvements.

We will continue to improve OpenOffice to provide the best and most valuable free office suite for our users.